COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Exploring FOSS communities

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Housekeeping

- Do we have notetakers for today's topics?
  - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
  - You should now be able to see start/target dates!
  - After submission, I will add a reviewer
- You should have all received an invitation to join as an "Outside Collaborator"

Today's Goals

- Look at the projects you shared for homework:
  - Common documents
  - Project activity
  - Communication channels
- Understand the various roles in FOSS communities

> *I will use Inkscape and QBittorrent as examples. Please pick 1-2 others to look at and answer questions during this class.*

Common (non-code) Documents

While there are no real "rules" to open source, most repos will contain:

- README
- LICENSE
- CONTRIBUTING
- INSTALL
- Maybe AGENTS, CODE_OF_CONDUCT, CODING_STYLE, etc

> *These are often in all-caps titled Markdown files, but neither is guaranteed*



What common documents do you see? How do they differ?

Evaluating project activity

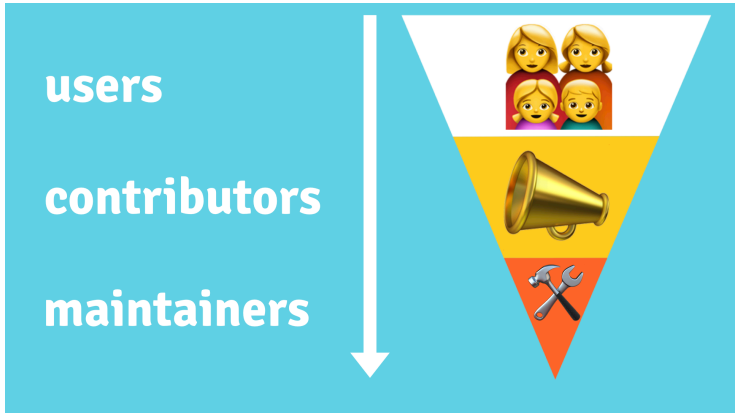
- Issues (GitHub) or Work Items (GitLab) are "to do" items
- Pull/merge requests are accomplishing the "to dos"
- Consider:
  - Which items get closed and why
  - Which get lots of comments
  - Age of open items
  - Tags
- What are the official communication channels, and how often do people post?



How active are the projects? What communication channels are most used?

Roles in FOSS projects

- You are already a **user** — might submit bug report
- This semester, you will become a **contributor**:
  - Reproduce bugs
  - Write code, documentation, translations
  - Someone will review your submission
- **Maintainers** are the project leaders who review and merge PRs, manage releases, etc
- The bus factor in FOSS is often very low!



Source: https://mikemcquaid.com/the-open-source-contributor-funnel-why-people-dont-contribute-to-your-open-source-project/



What are the key roles? Who are the people in these roles?

Next up

- Lab exercise: merging the PRs submitted last week
- Monday: special guest lecture on copyright and licensing
- Homework question: read about licensing